Canada Water Agency | Agence de l'eau du Canada

Community-Based Water Quality Monitoring in the Upper Great Lakes

Sault Ste. Marie Region Conservation Authority
SSMRCA

Building local knowledge and capacity to understand and protect our waters

About the project

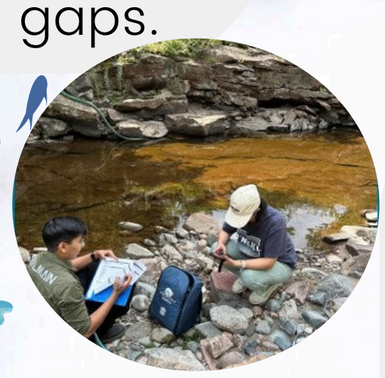
Communities lead, we support, waters win

We support community-led water quality monitoring from lower Lake Superior to Lake Huron's North Shore. Communities gain capacity to protect local waterways, expand community-based science, and address local priorities & data gaps.















How we engage

Awareness, training, place-making, action

- Identify sites, what to monitor, community priorities, and needed tools.
- Provide training, monitoring supplies, guidance, access to specialized expertise.
- Develop region-specific methods.
- Increase community cohesion and belonging between water protectors, their communities, and local waterways.
- Build pathways for community-based science to inform decisions.
- Recognize volunteer commitment through certificates, ribbons, and medals.
- Ensure accessible opportunities for all ages and abilities to learn, connect, and have fun.

5-year achievements (2021-2026)

Engagement, data, research, mentoring tomorrow's Northern Ontario water warriors

- **>75,000 social media impressions** improved awareness of water quality.
- **>10,000 people reached** at >40 public events - training, field sampling (chemistry, eDNA, insect surveys), classroom & laboratory sessions, and public outreach.
- **>200 volunteers** monitoring 46 sites collected **>45,000 data points** over 465 site visits.
- **67 youth mentored, trained, and/or hired** (52 Indigenous youth interns & hires from 15 First Nations across Canada + 15 post-secondary student placements).
- **8 communities** benefited from pilot monitoring programs and capacity development, 4 of which now independently manage their own permanent, expanded programs.
- **2 public campaigns** - microplastics & road salts (Ste. Marys River) - completed
- **2 community-driven special projects** - nutrients & E. coli (lower Lake Superior and Lake Huron's North Shore) - initiated (completion by March 2027).

FOLLOW US ON

OR

Northern Ontario Research, Development, Ideas and Knowledge
NORDIK INSTITUTE

Shaping Outreach, Understanding, Research and Community Engagement with Water